

A pro-innovation approach to AI governance requires safety and understanding

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Disasters are both intrinsically bad and lead to regulatory hammers. In the history of safety engineering, many major system failures all follow a certain loose story ([Dekker, 2019](#)). It starts off with some system – e.g., a dam, bridge, power plant, oil rig, building, etc – that functions normally for a long time. At first, this is accompanied by direct evidence of benefits and no evidence of major harms which can lull engineers into a false sense of security. But then, tragedy strikes suddenly. For example, before the infamous 1986 Challenger space shuttle explosion, there were 9 successful launches ([Gebhardt, 2011](#)) which was a factor that led engineers to neglect safety warnings before the infamous 10th launch. Things were fine, and the empirical evidence looked good until disaster struck. There is scientific consensus that AI is a very powerful technology and that it could pose national security threats. This points us to invest in safeguards while we develop it. If AI has a ‘Chernobyl moment,’ it would not only be tragic in and of itself, but would almost certainly trigger a regulatory hammer effect afterward ([Hendrycks, 2024](#)).

Democracies require information to function. Historically, AI has been developed in a very open way in the scientific community. However, in recent years, it has become both more impactful and more closed. This is often described as the “crisis of transparency” in AI. Currently, there is limited scientific understanding and even less public understanding of (1) how labs train their AI systems, (2) how their AI systems function internally, and (3) how they are governed internally. Having more transparency into this (e.g., by having companies produce documentation of their internal risk assessments) would improve public understanding and society’s ability to have more informed discussions about this emerging technology. It would also allow for more competitiveness and innovation in the AI space by increasing awareness of frontier practices.